How can you know how good a 'proxy' or 'surrogate' indicator is?

Sometimes, when doing indicator work, you cannot find an indicator for a higher-level box within the relevant DoView strategy/outcomes diagram. When this happens, a 'proxy' or 'surrogate' indicator is sometimes used.

The formal definition of a proxy indicator is that it is a measures of a lower-level box which leads on to higher-level boxe(s) within the relevant DoView strategy/outcomes diagram used as a proxy measure because a higher-level indicator cannot be identified.

Using a proxy indicator is always less desirable than having a measure for the higher-level box that you are wanting to measure. But proxy indicators are sometimes the only choice because of the low feasibility or high cost of finding and measuring a higher-level indicator. They are also sometimes chosen if you are looking for a controllable indicator for accountability purposes, which you can attribute to an organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative merely by measuring it. See Deliverables, Outputs and KPIs Checklist (D9). In such cases, you move down the DoView strategy/outcomes diagram until you find a suitable indicator that is controllable.

Proxy indicators are often presented without any information about the level at which they are located within the relevant strategy/outcomes diagram. Because of this, it is hard to determine how useful they are. A reader just looking at a proxy indicator does not have a quick way of knowing whether it measures a box close to the high-level of the strategy/outcomes diagram or outcomes framework, or one that is a long way lower down the diagram.

The most transparent approach to using proxy indicators is to always show them represented against the box they measure within the initiative's strategy/outcomes diagram. This means that the reader can immediately locate exactly how far down the diagram the proxy indicator is located. This Proxy Indicator Level Assessment Tool (D11) shows you how this can work.